二十四节气

太阳写下的日历

The 24 Solar Terms

A Calendar Written by the Sun

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 如果你在中国生活过一段时间，可能会发现，中国人常常说“今天立秋[1]了”或者“明天就是冬至[2]”。这些词既不是节日的名字，也不是月份的名字，而是“节气[3]”。一年有二十四个节气，它们像一张时间表[4]，告诉人们天气会怎么变化，什么时候应该做什么事情。这套时间表已经用了两千多年，到今天还和人们的生活有很多关系。

什么是节气

2 很多人以为，中国的传统历法[5]只看月亮。其实，中国的农历[6]是一种“阴阳历[7]”：月份是按照月亮的变化来定的，而节气是按照太阳来定的。地球一年绕[8]太阳转一圈。从地球上看，太阳在天空中的位置每天都会慢慢改变，一年正好走完三百六十度。

1 立秋 *lìqiū* Beginning of Autumn (solar term)
2 冬至 *dōngzhì* Winter Solstice (solar term)
3 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
4 时间表 *shíjiānbiǎo* timetable
5 历法 *lìfǎ* calendar system
6 农历 *nónglì* traditional (lunar) calendar
7 阴阳历 *yīnyánglì* lunisolar calendar
8 绕 *rào* to go around

If you have lived in China for a while, you may have noticed that people often say things like "Autumn begins today" or "Tomorrow is the Winter Solstice". These words are neither the names of festivals nor the names of months: they are "solar terms". There are twenty-four of them in a year. They work like a timetable, telling people how the weather is going to change and what they should be doing when. This timetable has been in use for more than two thousand years, and it is still closely tied to people's lives today. 1

What Are the Solar Terms?

Many people think that the traditional Chinese calendar is based on the moon alone. In fact, the Chinese traditional calendar is a "lunisolar" calendar: the months follow the phases of the moon, while the solar terms follow the sun. The earth goes once around the sun every year. Seen from the earth, the sun's position in the sky shifts a little every day, and in one year it travels exactly 360 degrees. 2

2 古人[1]把这三百六十度分成[2]二十四份，每份十五度。太阳每走过十五度，就是一个新的节气[3]，大约十五天一次。

3 因为节气是按照太阳来算的，所以它们在公历[4]上的日期几乎不变。比如，冬至[5]总是在十二月二十一日或者二十二日，清明[6]总是在四月四日或者五日左右。相反，春节和中秋节[7]这些按照月亮来算的节日，每年的公历日期都不一样。

4 为什么古人需要节气呢？原因很简单：种地。农历[8]的一个月是按照月亮计算的，大约二十九天半，十二个月加起来只有三百五十四天左右，比一年少了十一天。如果只看月份，几年以后，“三月”可能就跑到冬天去了。农民需要知道真正的季节，才能决定什么时候种地，什么时候收庄稼[9]。节气正好解决了这个问题。

1 古人 *gǔrén* the ancients
2 分成 *fēnchéng* to divide into
3 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
4 公历 *gōnglì* Gregorian calendar
5 冬至 *dōngzhì* Winter Solstice (solar term)
6 清明 *qīngmíng* Pure Brightness (solar term)
7 中秋节 *Zhōngqiūjié* Mid-Autumn Festival
8 农历 *nónglì* traditional (lunar) calendar
9 庄稼 *zhuāngjia* crops

The ancient Chinese divided these 360 degrees into twenty-four parts of fifteen degrees each. Every time the sun moves on by fifteen degrees, a new solar term begins – roughly once every fifteen days. 2

Because the solar terms are calculated from the sun, their dates in the Western calendar hardly change. The Winter Solstice, for example, always falls on 21 or 22 December, and Pure Brightness always comes around 4 or 5 April. By contrast, festivals reckoned by the moon, such as the Spring Festival and the Mid-Autumn Festival, fall on a different Western date every year. 3

Why did people in ancient times need the solar terms? The reason is simple: farming. A lunar month lasts about twenty-nine and a half days, so twelve months add up to only about 354 days – eleven days short of a full year. If you went by the months alone, after a few years the "third month" might have wandered into winter. Farmers needed to know the real season in order to decide when to sow and when to bring in the harvest. The solar terms solved exactly this problem. 4

5 二十四节气[1]最早出现在黄河[2]流域[3]，那里的人们观察太阳、天气和植物，慢慢总结出了这些规律。到了两千多年前的汉代[4]，二十四个节气已经全部确定下来了。2016年，联合国教科文组织[5]把二十四节气列入了人类非物质文化遗产[6]名录。

6 二十四节气的名字都很有意思。有的名字告诉我们季节开始了，比如立春[7]、立夏[8]、立秋[9]、立冬[10]，“立”[11]就是“开始”的意思；有的名字说的是天气冷热，比如小暑[12]、大暑[13]、小寒[14]、大寒[15]；有的说的是雨和雪，比如雨水[16]、谷雨[17]、小雪[18]、大雪[19]；还有的跟农业有关[20]，比如芒种[21]。只看名字，人们就能大概知道那个时候的天气是什么样子。

1 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
2 黄河 *Huáng Hé* Yellow River
3 流域 *liúyù* river basin
4 汉代 *Hàndài* Han dynasty (206 BC–AD 220)
5 联合国教科文组织 *Liánhéguó Jiàokēwén Zǔzhī* UNESCO
6 非物质文化遗产 *fēiwùzhì wénhuà yíchǎn* intangible cultural heritage
7 立春 *lìchūn* Beginning of Spring
8 立夏 *lìxià* Beginning of Summer
9 立秋 *lìqiū* Beginning of Autumn (solar term)
10 立冬 *lìdōng* Beginning of Winter
11 立 *lì* to stand; to begin
12 小暑 *xiǎoshǔ* Minor Heat
13 大暑 *dàshǔ* Major Heat
14 小寒 *xiǎohán* Minor Cold
15 大寒 *dàhán* Major Cold
16 雨水 *yǔshuǐ* Rain Water (solar term)
17 谷雨 *gǔyǔ* Grain Rain
18 小雪 *xiǎoxuě* Minor Snow
19 大雪 *dàxuě* Major Snow
20 有关 *yǒuguān* to be related to
21 芒种 *mángzhòng* Grain in Ear

The twenty-four solar terms first appeared in the Yellow River basin, where people watched the sun, the weather and the plants and gradually worked out these patterns. By the Han dynasty, more than two thousand years ago, all twenty-four terms had been fixed. In 2016, UNESCO added the twenty-four solar terms to its list of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. 5

The names of the twenty-four solar terms are all interesting. Some tell us that a season has begun, such as the Beginning of Spring, of Summer, of Autumn and of Winter – here 立 means "to begin"; some describe heat and cold, such as Minor Heat, Major Heat, Minor Cold and Major Cold; some are about rain and snow, such as Rain Water, Grain Rain, Minor Snow and Major Snow; and others are related to farming, such as Grain in Ear. From the name alone, people can get a rough idea of what the weather is like at that time. 6

春天的节气[1]

立春[2]是二十四节气中的第一个，一般在二月四日前后，离春节很近。虽然这个时候北方还很冷，但是白天已经越来越长，人们知道春天就要来了。在一些地方，人们立春这天要吃春饼[3]，把各种蔬菜[4]卷在薄饼[5]里，叫做“咬春[6]”。

三月初是惊蛰[7]。“蛰[8]”指的是冬天藏[9]在地下睡觉的小动物和虫子。古人[10]认为，到了这个时候，天上开始打雷，雷声把这些虫子惊醒[11]了，所以叫“惊蛰”。其实，虫子醒来主要是因为天气变暖[12]了，但是这个名字非常形象。惊蛰以后，很多地方的农民开始忙着春耕[13]。

1 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
2 立春 *lìchūn* Beginning of Spring
3 春饼 *chūnbǐng* spring pancakes
4 蔬菜 *shūcài* vegetables
5 薄饼 *báobǐng* thin pancake
6 咬春 *yǎochūn* “biting into spring”
7 惊蛰 *jīngzhé* Awakening of Insects
8 蛰 *zhé* to hibernate
9 藏 *cáng* to hide
10 古人 *gǔrén* the ancients
11 惊醒 *jīngxǐng* to wake with a start
12 暖 *nuǎn* warm
13 春耕 *chūngēng* spring ploughing

The Solar Terms of Spring

The Beginning of Spring is the first of the twenty-four solar terms. It usually falls around 4 February, close to the Spring Festival. Although the north is still cold at this time, the days are already getting longer, and people know that spring is on its way. In some places people eat spring pancakes on this day, rolling all kinds of vegetables up in thin pancakes – a custom called "biting into spring". 7

Early March brings the Awakening of Insects. The character 蛰 refers to the small animals and insects that spend the winter asleep underground. People in ancient times believed that at this point thunder began to roll across the sky and startled these insects awake – hence the name. In reality the insects wake up mainly because the weather has turned warmer, but the name paints a vivid picture. After the Awakening of Insects, farmers in many places get busy with the spring ploughing. 8

9 清明[1]在四月四日或者五日左右，它既是一个节气[2]，也是一个重要的节日。这个时候天气变得清爽[3]明亮[4]，所以叫“清明”。清明节[5]最重要的活动是扫墓[6]，人们回到家乡，打扫亲人的墓[7]，送上鲜花，表达对祖先[8]的思念[9]。同时，春天的风景也很美，很多人会去郊外[10]踏青[11]、放风筝[12]。在江南[13]地区[15]，人们还喜欢吃一种绿色的点心[14]，叫青团。

夏天和秋天的节气

10 五月下旬[16]有一个节气叫小满[17]。这时候，小麦[18]等粮食已经开始变得饱满[19]，但是还没有完全成熟，所以叫“小满”。

1 清明 *qīngmíng* Pure Brightness (solar term)
2 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
3 清爽 *qīngshuǎng* fresh and clear
4 明亮 *míngliàng* bright
5 清明节 *Qīngmíngjié* Qingming (Tomb-Sweeping) Festival
6 扫墓 *sǎomù* to sweep the graves
7 墓 *mù* grave
8 祖先 *zǔxiān* ancestors
9 思念 *sīniàn* longing, remembrance
10 郊外 *jiāowài* the countryside outside town
11 踏青 *tàqīng* to go on a spring outing
12 风筝 *fēngzheng* kite
13 江南 *Jiāngnán* Jiangnan, the region south of the lower Yangtze
14 点心 *diǎnxin* pastry, snack
15 青团 *qīngtuán* green rice ball
16 下旬 *xiàxún* last ten days of a month
17 小满 *xiǎomǎn* Grain Buds (“Small Fullness”)
18 小麦 *xiǎomài* wheat
19 饱满 *bǎomǎn* plump, full

Pure Brightness comes around 4 or 5 April. It is both a solar term and an important festival. At this time of year the weather turns fresh and bright, and that is where the name comes from. The most important custom of the Qingming Festival is sweeping the graves: people return to their home towns, tidy the graves of their relatives, lay fresh flowers and remember their ancestors. At the same time the spring scenery is lovely, and many people go out into the countryside for a spring walk or to fly kites. In the Jiangnan region, people also like to eat a green sweet called qingtuan. 9

The Solar Terms of Summer and Autumn

In late May there is a solar term called Small Fullness. At this time wheat and other grains are starting to fill out but are not yet fully ripe – hence "small fullness". 10

10 有意思的是，二十四节气[1]里有小暑[2]也有大暑[3]，有小雪[4]也有大雪[5]，却只有小满[6]，没有“大满[7]”。很多人认为，这反映了中国人的一种想法：事情不要做得太满，留一点儿空间，才是最好的状态。

11 小满后面就是芒种[8]，一般在六月初。“芒[9]”指的是麦子[10]上细细的尖[11]毛。这个时候，北方要收麦子，南方要种水稻[12]，是农民一年中最忙的时候之一。

12 六月二十一日前后是夏至[13]。在北半球，这一天白天最长，夜晚[14]最短。过了夏至，天气会越来越热，真正的夏天开始了。

1 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
2 小暑 *xiǎoshǔ* Minor Heat
3 大暑 *dàshǔ* Major Heat
4 小雪 *xiǎoxuě* Minor Snow
5 大雪 *dàxuě* Major Snow
6 小满 *xiǎomǎn* Grain Buds (“Small Fullness”)
7 大满 *dàmǎn* “great fullness” (not a solar term)
8 芒种 *mángzhòng* Grain in Ear
9 芒 *máng* awn (bristle on an ear of grain)
10 麦子 *màizi* wheat
11 尖 *jiān* pointed
12 水稻 *shuǐdào* paddy rice
13 夏至 *xiàzhì* Summer Solstice
14 夜晚 *yèwǎn* night

Interestingly, among the twenty-four terms there is a Minor Heat and a Major Heat, a Minor Snow and a Major Snow, but only a Small Fullness and no "Great Fullness". Many people see this as a reflection of a Chinese way of thinking: don't push things to the very limit – leaving a little room is the best state to be in. 10

After Small Fullness comes Grain in Ear, usually in early June. 芒 refers to the fine, pointed bristles on ears of wheat. At this time the north is harvesting wheat and the south is planting rice, so it is one of the busiest times of the year for farmers. 11

Around 21 June comes the Summer Solstice. In the Northern Hemisphere this is the longest day and the shortest night of the year. After the solstice the weather keeps getting hotter: real summer has begun. 12

12 北方有“冬至[1]饺子夏至[2]面”的说法[3]，所以很多人夏至这天会吃一碗凉面[4]。

13 八月七日或者八日前后是立秋[5]。按照节气[6]，秋天从这一天开始了，可是实际上，很多地方还非常热，人们把立秋以后的热天叫做“秋老虎[7]”。立秋还有一个有意思的习惯叫“贴秋膘[8]”：夏天太热，很多人吃得少，人也瘦[9]了，所以到了立秋，大家要多吃一点儿肉，把夏天瘦掉的补回来。

14 九月二十三日前后是秋分[10]。和春分[11]一样，这一天白天和夜晚[12]差不多一样长。秋分的时候，很多庄稼[13]已经成熟，农民忙着收获。从2018年开始，中国把每年的秋分定为“中国农民丰收节[14]”，在这一天，各地都会举行庆祝活动。

1 冬至 *dōngzhì* Winter Solstice (solar term)
2 夏至 *xiàzhì* Summer Solstice
3 说法 *shuōfǎ* saying
4 凉面 *liángmiàn* cold noodles
5 立秋 *lìqiū* Beginning of Autumn (solar term)
6 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
7 秋老虎 *qiūlǎohǔ* “autumn tiger”, late-summer heat
8 贴秋膘 *tiē qiūbiāo* “putting on autumn fat”
9 瘦 *shòu* thin
10 秋分 *qiūfēn* Autumn Equinox
11 春分 *chūnfēn* Spring Equinox
12 夜晚 *yèwǎn* night
13 庄稼 *zhuāngjia* crops
14 中国农民丰收节 *Zhōngguó Nóngmín Fēngshōujié* Chinese Farmers' Harvest Festival

In the north there is a saying, "dumplings at the Winter Solstice, noodles at the Summer Solstice", so many people eat a bowl of cold noodles on this day. 12

The Beginning of Autumn falls around 7 or 8 August. According to the solar terms autumn starts on this day, but in reality many places are still extremely hot. People call the hot days after the Beginning of Autumn the "autumn tiger". There is another interesting custom at the Beginning of Autumn, called "putting on autumn fat": summer is so hot that many people eat little and lose weight, so when autumn begins everyone eats a bit more meat to make up for what they lost over the summer. 13

The Autumn Equinox comes around 23 September. As at the Spring Equinox, day and night are about the same length. By the equinox many crops are ripe, and farmers are busy bringing in the harvest. Since 2018, China has made the Autumn Equinox the "Chinese Farmers' Harvest Festival", and celebrations are held all over the country on that day. 14

冬天的节气[1]

15 冬至[2]在十二月二十一日或者二十二日，是北半球白天最短、夜晚[3]最长的一天。在古代，冬至是一个非常重要的日子，有“冬至大如年[4]”的说法[5]，意思是冬至和过年差不多一样重要。今天，北方人冬至常常吃饺子，南方很多地方吃汤圆[6]。还有一个流传很广[7]的说法：冬至不吃饺子，耳朵[8]会冻[9]掉。这当然只是一句玩笑，但是很多人每年冬至还是会认真地吃一顿饺子。

16 从冬至开始，人们还会“数九[10]”：每九天是一个“九”，一共九个“九”，八十一天。数完了这八十一天，冬天就过去了，天气也暖和了。

1 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
2 冬至 *dōngzhì* Winter Solstice (solar term)
3 夜晚 *yèwǎn* night
4 冬至大如年 *dōngzhì dà rú nián* “the Winter Solstice is as big as New Year”
5 说法 *shuōfǎ* saying
6 汤圆 *tāngyuán* sweet rice dumplings
7 广 *guǎng* wide, widely
8 耳朵 *ěrduo* ears
9 冻 *dòng* to freeze
10 数九 *shǔjiǔ* to count the nines (of winter)

The Solar Terms of Winter

The Winter Solstice falls on 21 or 22 December. In the Northern Hemisphere 15
it is the day with the shortest daylight and the longest night. In ancient times the Winter Solstice was a very important day. A saying goes that "the Winter Solstice is as big as New Year", meaning it mattered almost as much as the New Year itself. Today, northerners usually eat dumplings at the Winter Solstice, while in many places in the south people eat tangyuan. There is also a widespread saying that if you don't eat dumplings at the Winter Solstice, your ears will freeze off. It is only a joke, of course, but every year at the solstice many people still make a point of sitting down to a meal of dumplings.

Starting from the Winter Solstice, people also "count the nines": every nine 16
days make one "nine", and there are nine "nines" in all – eighty-one days. When these eighty-one days have been counted, winter is over and the weather has turned warm.

16 以前，有的人会在冬至[1]那天画一枝[2]梅花[3]，上面有八十一个花瓣[4]，每天给一个花瓣涂[5]上颜色，等所有的花瓣都涂完了，春天也就来了。

17 冬至以后是小寒[6]和大寒[7]，这是一年中最冷的时候。大寒之后，下一个节气[8]又是立春[9]，二十四节气就这样一年一年地循环[10]下去。

今天的节气

18 现在的农民有天气预报，也有各种现代技术，不再[11]完全依靠节气来安排农活。但是，节气并没有离开人们的生活。电视上的天气预报常常会提到节气，比如“今天是大雪[12]，北方将[13]迎来[14]降温”。

1 冬至 *dōngzhì* Winter Solstice (solar term)
2 枝 *zhī* (measure word for branches)
3 梅花 *méihuā* plum blossom
4 花瓣 *huābàn* petal
5 涂 *tú* to paint, to colour
6 小寒 *xiǎohán* Minor Cold
7 大寒 *dàhán* Major Cold
8 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
9 立春 *lìchūn* Beginning of Spring
10 循环 *xúnhuán* to go round in a cycle
11 不再 *bùzài* no longer
12 大雪 *dàxuě* Major Snow
13 将 *jiāng* will, is going to
14 迎来 *yínglái* to welcome, to usher in

In the past, some people would draw a branch of plum blossom with eighty-one petals on the day of the solstice and colour in one petal each day. By the time every petal was coloured, spring had arrived. 16

After the Winter Solstice come Minor Cold and Major Cold, the coldest time of the year. After Major Cold the next term is once again the Beginning of Spring, and so the twenty-four solar terms go round and round, year after year. 17

The Solar Terms Today

Farmers today have weather forecasts and all kinds of modern technology, and no longer rely entirely on the solar terms to plan their work. But the solar terms have not disappeared from people's lives. Weather forecasts on television often mention them – "Today is Major Snow, and temperatures in the north are set to drop." 18

18 手机里的日历也会标[1]出每一个节气[2]。

19 需要注意的是，二十四节气是根据黄河[3]流域[4]的气候总结出来的。中国很大，南方和北方的天气差别[5]很大，所以在广州[6]或者哈尔滨[7]，节气和真实的天气不一定完全一样。大雪[8]那天，广州的人可能还穿着短袖[9]。

20 很多中国人也按照节气来照顾自己的身体。中医认为，人应该跟着季节的变化生活：春天要早起，多到外面活动；夏天要注意别太热；秋天天气干燥[10]，可以多吃梨[11]；冬天要注意保暖[12]，多吃一些温暖的食物。不管这些说法[13]有没有科学根据，很多家庭都把它们当作[14]生活习惯。

1 标 *biāo* to mark
2 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
3 黄河 *Huáng Hé* Yellow River
4 流域 *liúyù* river basin
5 差别 *chābié* difference
6 广州 *Guǎngzhōu* Guangzhou (Canton)
7 哈尔滨 *Hā'ěrbīn* Harbin
8 大雪 *dàxuě* Major Snow
9 短袖 *duǎnxiù* short sleeves
10 干燥 *gānzào* dry
11 梨 *lí* pear
12 保暖 *bǎonuǎn* to keep warm
13 说法 *shuōfǎ* saying
14 当作 *dàngzuò* to treat as

The calendars on people's phones mark every solar term as well. 18

It is worth remembering that the twenty-four solar terms were worked out from the climate of the Yellow River basin. China is huge and the weather in the south and the north differs greatly, so in Guangzhou or Harbin the solar terms do not always match the real weather. On the day of Major Snow, people in Guangzhou may still be wearing short sleeves. 19

Many Chinese people also look after their health according to the solar terms. Traditional Chinese medicine holds that people should live in step with the changing seasons: get up early in spring and spend more time outdoors; take care not to overheat in summer; in dry autumn weather, eat plenty of pears; and in winter, stay warm and eat warming food. Whether or not these ideas have any scientific basis, many families treat them as part of everyday life. 20

21 在网上，每到一个新的节气[1]，很多公司、博物馆[2]和普通人都会发一张漂亮的图片，配上节气的名字。2022年北京冬奥会[3]的开幕式[4]上，倒计时[5]也用了二十四节气，最后一个是立春[6]——开幕式那天正好就是立春。全世界的观众通过电视看到了这套古老[7]的时间系统。

结语

22 二十四节气是古人[8]观察太阳和自然的结果，也是他们留给后人[9]的一份礼物。它提醒我们，人的生活和季节、土地、天气紧密地联系在一起。即使[10]住在城市里，我们也可以停下来，看看窗外的天空和树木[11]，感受一下：今天是什么节气？

1 节气 *jiéqì* solar term
2 博物馆 *bówùguǎn* museum
3 冬奥会 *Dōng'àohuì* Winter Olympics
4 开幕式 *kāimùshì* opening ceremony
5 倒计时 *dàojìshí* countdown
6 立春 *lìchūn* Beginning of Spring
7 古老 *gǔlǎo* ancient
8 古人 *gǔrén* the ancients
9 后人 *hòurén* later generations
10 即使 *jíshǐ* even if
11 树木 *shùmù* trees

Online, whenever a new solar term arrives, companies, museums and ordi- 21
nary people post a beautiful picture with the name of the term. At the opening ceremony of the 2022 Beijing Winter Olympics, the countdown used the twenty-four solar terms, ending with the Beginning of Spring – which was exactly the day of the ceremony. Viewers all over the world saw this ancient system of time on their televisions.

In Closing

The twenty-four solar terms are the fruit of ancient people's observation of 22
the sun and of nature, and a gift they left to those who came after them. They remind us that human life is closely bound up with the seasons, the land and the weather. Even if we live in a city, we can stop for a moment, look at the sky and the trees outside the window, and ask ourselves: which solar term is it today?